

Sophia Vona
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A Space in Flux: Sensory Ethnography of the HHIVE Lab

The HHIVE Lab is a space I repeatedly return to. The soft lighting, the bright swirls of the carpets, and the plush fabric of the couch have all become familiar to me. These sensory impressions, briefly glimpsed as I flit from one project to the next, are anchors that ground my experience of the lab— at first glance, they appear to be constants, unmoving despite the people who come and go, and the ever-changing projects developing, shifting and morphing works within its walls. Yet this conceptualization of the space ignores what Pink, drawing on Edward Casey's Phenomenological theory of place, describes as the "gathering power" of space, where different types of "things," from the inanimate to even our "experiences" and "thoughts" can be held together (Pink 13). This conceptualization of place as fluid reveals the ever-changing nature of spaces we inhabit.

To better understand the fluidity of the space, I conducted a sensory ethnography drawing from Pink's theory of emplacement— a framework which moves beyond embodiment's mind-body integration to account for the "sensuous interrelationship of the body-mind-environment," an axis which Pink derives from Howes. While embodiment describes the body as a site of knowing, emplacement accounts for the relationship between one's mind, body and the "materiality" of the environment (5-6). This framework centers the "experience" and "event" of a space, constructed by all three entities described (6), making place something that is active, reflexive, and ever-shifting as all three entities shift: in other words, "constantly changing and subject to redefinition" (6). Derek McCormack best expands on the affective and sensory feelings which are produced as these three entities interact: in his theory of atmosphere, these three entities generate spaces which are "diffuse," unlike a traditional object, yet can still be "felt," and "palpably affective," transcending the idea that spaces are simply observed (McCormack 91). Ultimately, both of these theories center the relationality and fluidity

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of space, allowing for an emergent understanding of the space that goes beyond an understanding of space as merely between four walls or a constant.

To better understand my own experience of the space of HHIVE lab, I draw on these interrelational theories. In analyzing my field notes from three separate visits to this space, I argue that sound functions as the primary medium through which I am emplaced within the room and through which the atmosphere of the room is constituted. When the room is empty, the collapse of the usual soundscape into an unwavering drone reveals the dependence of the room's atmosphere on sound. When the room is populated, other people's sounds form a collective energy: the "buzz" of the HHIVE lab, which registers in the body as physical sensation even when discrete or specific auditory information is not absorbed. Finally, with headphones in and a populated room, an artificial soundscape narrows my emplacement to a smaller sphere, constructing a micro-space within the larger space that only I inhabit. In this way, the modulations of sound within the HHIVE lab reveal the interrelated, fluid, and atmospheric space I am emplaced within.

Solitary Spaces

On February 25th at 1:07 PM, I was the only person in the HHIVE lab. In the empty room, the collapse of the usual soundscape into a single unwavering drone revealed what the populated room had always obscured: that sound, more than any other sensory channel, can reveal how mental habits and sensorial bodily experience come together to construct the HHIVE lab space. Though familiar visual and tactile sensations immediately became apparent, it took dwelling in the loneliness of my mental affect for the materiality of the space to shift: the novel sounds and materiality of the space interacted with and reinforced a lonely mental habit, thus constituting my overall experience of the HHIVE lab space. Indeed, the visual and tactile features of the space were familiar and stable: I noted my body "sink[ing]" into the red couch

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behind me, the “bright colors around me” such as in the capet, as well as my “atrocious” posture and the darkness of the wooden table (Fieldnotes, 25 Feb 2025, 1:07PM). Yet in the solitude of the experience, my auditory senses came to the forefront in a way they typically do not: “I can hear a hum to my right. I believe it’s the AC. [I]t’s constant, unwavering, one tone” (Fieldnotes, 25 Feb 2025, 1:07PM). I do not doubt that the AC has always been present when I go to the HHIVE lab, but I rarely notice it. This dynamic is clarified by my field note observation that “I realize that in this place I tend to quickly turn to sound. The visual cues and the feelings are familiar. The sounds snap my focus to new objects” (Fieldnotes, 25 Feb 2025, 1:07PM). This language of “snap[ping]” insists on an immediacy, a magnitude of effect, that only sound brought for me in this instant. This illustrates the reason why sound became central to me.

Simultaneously, my mental state had shifted to that of a sort of casual loneliness and subtle longing for others— casual in the sense that it is not dire or extreme, just slightly annoying to the extroverted among us who like to have others sharing spaces with them. I know this because I wrote “I wish someone else would come to the space” (Fieldnotes, 25 Feb 2025, 1:07PM). The soundscape and my mental state had both shifted. As Pink argues, place is “constantly changing and subject to redefinition” (Pink 6), and for me, that redefinition came through the shifting of the individual factors which bring out space in the first place. Though attending to sound, the casual loneliness of the space— fueled by my mental state and the bodily sensorial experience noticed as auditory stimulation— came to the forefront of my experience of the space.

These shifts in space are also reflexive and build on themselves: once the casual loneliness of the space was constructed, I further fixated on sounds that pointed towards interaction with others. For example, I wrote “I hear someone open a door outside the lab. Maybe a professor in their office?” as well as “I hear the sink turn on. [Is it someone in t]he bathroom?” The auditory had become a medium to express my mental habit, as I reached

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towards potential others. In this way, the emergence of a space of casual loneliness in the HHIVE lab demonstrates not only how the mental and sensorial co-construct space, but that they intermingle, further demonstrating Pink's claims about the relationality of the factors which construct space.

The Buzz of a social space

By 12:41 PM on March 9th, the room had filled, and the shift in my emplacement was immediate: The casual loneliness of the space was reconstituted into a buzzing space, as my auditory observations shifted towards livelier expressions of sociality and connection. This was expressed by my frequent audio based sensorial remarks of the space, revealing how the auditory rises again in constitution space: "I hear the chairs rolling around as people move back and forth," and "Someone just walked in," which I knew because "I hear[d] their bookbag zipping, the clanks as they set up their space." Finally, I heard the person "grab a snack. The crinkle of the food bags" (Fieldnotes, 9 Mar. 2025, 12:47 PM¹). Throughout the fieldnotes, it becomes clear that the audio-based materiality and bodily sensation of sound continued to be my most salient tool for constructing and experiencing the space.

In this social space, my ability to experience the atmosphere flourished: I understood the sociality of the space not only through the accumulation of bodies but as McCormack's atmospheric space. My extra-sensory, atmospheric understanding of the space was piqued by auditory sensations: According to McCormack, the atmosphere is constituted by "sometimes relatively discrete presences," which "emerge from and can also contribute to the generation of diffuse yet palpably affective, atmospheric spacetimes" (McCormack 91). The diffuse, effective atmosphere is best described by my fieldwork remark that "I am aware of a presence¹. I feel the

¹ The presence was Dr. Weed at her desk, to the left of me at the couch!

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person at the desk to the left of me, I hear them typing. I feel the person sitting at the table, facing me but focused on her own work. My awareness being pulled to them feels like a weight in the other side of the room, prickling the sides of my body where they face” (Fieldnotes, 9 Mar. 2025, 12:47 PM). The discrete experience was that, I could “hear” their keyboard keys clacking, again centering the auditory in my experience of a materiality of a space. However, the atmospheric dimensions is my awareness of their presence with a “prickling”, which “pulls” my attention and which I can “feel.” Though these words allude to tactile sensation, they are not informed by actual tactile nerve stimulation, and thus represent an atmospheric emergence: the presence of others, which can only emerge in a social space. The *buzz* of the social space emerged, which was not just noise, but was a collective atmosphere, which I registered across bodies with the aid of auditory sensorial information. Moreover, the ability of this space to emerge socially, contrasting it to the casual loneliness of the space, demonstrates the ever-changing nature of any given space.

The Headphones Experiment

To further my understanding of the role of auditory stimulation in constructing space, I decided to attempt to put on headphones while in HHIVE while others were there (ie, the social space) in order to see if this shifted my experience of space. Though this decision will inevitably create a bias towards an analysis of the auditory, it allows for deeper exploration into this facet of the sensorial in the experience of space: in other words, the bias is the point. McCormack writes that method “can be about attending to things as they happen in a more responsive, risky way” (93)-- though introducing bias is the risk, the reward is the responsive awareness and the fruits of further attending to this sense.

On March 9th at 3 PM, I put my headphones on while other remained in the space. Though my earlier experience of the sensory space had revealed an atmosphere of presence

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lingered, my shifted auditory experience lent itself more to an atmosphere of internality and closer borders, blocking out the presence around me. As I wrote in my fieldnotes, I felt “fixed, very still,” as if I am “wrapped in a box, a comfortable box, [and] everything else is blocked;” I noticed “the three sides of the couch coccooning me. I feel my laptop pressing on my lap, as if there are beams connecting my head to my computer. I curve my back, leaning into it...”

(Fieldnotes, 9 Mar. 2025, 3:00 PM). Interestingly, I do not explicitly invoke the auditory, but with headphones in, I am completely reoriented: my “cocoon[]” and my “box” alongside the fact that I “block” everything else shows how my space shrinks to hold only me and my immediate surroundings, and the fact that I am “still,” feel the “beams” from my head to my computer and “curve my back” to “lean[]” into my computer similarly implies a focus and a fixedness on a limited area. Auditory stimulation, again, becomes central to my construction of an atmosphere of internality and closed borders, but in this case, it does so by allowing me to zoom into other senses like the tactile.²

Interestingly, though McCormack implies that atmosphere can be shared when he writes that “Atmospheres gesture towards the sense of affective excess between and across bodies” (96), this reorientation was only in my head— the auditory stimulation was mine and mine alone, and thus the space became only something I could inhabit. My experiment proved the importance of sound on constructing space, but also demonstrated an interesting facet of space: you can exist in one by yourself, even with others around.

Though auditory sensorial processing orients me towards space, it is ultimately shown to be in service of a larger goal: demonstrating the fluidity and magnificent dimensions of space, as a constructed dimension, affected by multiple factors such as materiality, body and mind, as

² This illustrates what Pink means when she argues that the senses are “just different facets of the same activity: that of the whole organism in its environment” (Pink 8): though auditory takes the forefront for me, it does not deliver information in isolation, and other senses all contribute to the same construction of space.

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Pink writes. Across the three visits to the HHIVE Lab, these factors allowed for the emergence of a variety of spaces and widely different emplacements: In the solitary space, a lonely mental affect oriented me toward sounds I had never consciously registered, revealing how the interaction between mental state and materiality constitutes the space we inhabit. In the social space, discrete auditory stimuli accumulated into a diffuse atmospheric presence felt as weight and prickling against the body — a collective buzz that exceeded what any single sound could produce and that could only emerge between bodies. With headphones in, a privately substituted soundscape contracted my emplacement into a micro-space inhabited by me alone, demonstrating that though space existing "between and across bodies," as McCormack describes, singular spaces can emerge within larger ones (McCormack 96). Within the shifts of mind, body and materiality, space itself shifts. So the HHIVE lab may seem the same, but I have learned that the space that I step into nearly every week will never be the exact same every time.

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Field Notes, HHIVE Lab. 25 Feb. 2026, 1:07 PM

- I can leave my bookbag here between my class and my lab hours, go get some food and come back. It is an easy retreat. I find myself coming here often after class.
- Normally there are a lot of overlapping conversations. Right now I am the only one in here. I can hear a hum to my right. I believe it's the AC. it's constant, unwavering, one tone.
- My body sinks into the red couch behind me. I feel my elbows propped up on the back.
- I wonder why I am so drawn to these couches whenever I have lab hours? I used to go to the desks. I probably got a lot more work done with my back supported and my feet flat, but recently I am more drawn to the comfort of sinking into the couch, having my computer on my lap, with absolutely atrocious posture.
- There are bright colors around me. The carpet has all sorts of flowers in bright oranges and light pinks, faint yellows and deep blues. The couch is a deep red, even the wooden table in front of me seems to stand out in a sense (much more than my wooden living room table at home, which is dark and doesn't call much attention to itself)
- I hear someone open a door outside the lab. Maybe a professor in their office?
- I hear the sink turn on. The bathroom?
- I feel a little chilly. I pulled my sweatshirt on. I turn to the left, setting my back against the "arm" of the couch. I sink in a little further. I love couches like this- surround me on three sides, and with my computer on top of me, i feel so cocooned. Adding my sweatshirt made me feel even more cocooned.
- There is an indentation in the red cushion from where my back just was.
- I wish someone else would come to the space. Typically I enjoy the quiet drone of people. It makes it harder to work, so I always end up putting my headphones in to tune them out, but I also feel incredibly aware of my self currently and would love to add some observations about others in the space
- I heard the teacher(?) again opening her door. I think I heard a soft sound of something landing, which i imagine to be a paper landing in a wire trashcan.
- Footsteps. boots?
- I realize that in this place i tend to quickly turn to sound. The visual cues and the feelings are familiar. The sounds snap my focus to new objects.
- The static hum of the ac faded for a while. It's back. I wonder what brought it back.
- I keep reaching to check my email or open my phone instead of just sitting here, observing. My attention is absolutely shot from years of tik tok at this point, It is so hard to stay still with what feels like an amorphous task of observing. I think I've conditioned myself to associate this room with work, so I feel the urge to whip out an essay and start studying.

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Field Notes, HHIVE Lab. 9 Mar. 2026, 12:41 PM

- I am in the same corner. There's more people here now.
- I hear the chairs rolling around as people move back and forth
- I hear people's voices rising and falling. Usually this is when I would put my headphones in to tune out to get work done.
- I am aware of a presence. I feel the person at the desk to the left of me, I hear them typing. I feel the person sitting at the table, facing me but focused on her own work. My awareness being pulled to them feels like a weight in the other side of the room, prickling the sides of my body where they face, as I try to keep my gaze on my computer as to not seem like a creep
- Someone just walked in. I hear their bookbag zipping, the clanks as they set up their space. A personal work space within a shared space.
- They grab a snack. The crinkle of the food bags make me glance at my own lunch. Their attention to their lunch pulls my attention to my lunch.

Field Notes, HHIVE Lab. 9 Mar. 2026, 3:00 PM

- While with headphones in.
- It is noise that shakes me out of my focus: "YAAAAY." The auditory draws me out of my solitary corner,
- When my headphones are in, my eyes hang gently on my keyboard. I believe before I wrote this down they had glazed over a little. They felt fixed, I felt very still, as I listened to the music. This was actually likely more about the assignment than the music. Now typing, my eyes feel more fixed, my window of observation feels glued to the screen and my computer, with the noise coming through my headphones.
- I don't think I would feel like ^^ that without this assignment. I think my eyes would drift over everything. I think my "Focus" on observing shifts my focus to the screen, because otherwise I fear I will drift off and forget to write my observations. That being said, I drifted off and forgot to write anything down until I heard the "yayyy."
- I click to spotify to skip to the next song. I can feel my fingers on the keyboard
- my eyes are glued to the screen. There is no need for them to be exactly, but as I listen, It has to be very loud to knock me out of the fixation
- Similarly to my first field assignment, I feel the three sides of the couch coccooning me. I feel my laptop pressing on my lap, as if there are beams connecting my head to my computer. I curve my back, leaning into it.
- I feel wrapped in a box, a comfortable box, everything else is blocked.